E2 Speaking & Listening – Exam Prep Lesson 9: Describing things – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to describe an object by size, shape, material and use, and to keep talking when they do not know the English word. This prepares Task 3 and is the best protection against silence in the exam.

Materials: Handout E2-9A, one per learner. A cloth bag with eight real objects: keys, a mug, scissors, a phone charger, an umbrella, a torch, a sponge, a wooden spoon. One photo of a kitchen table or desk with many objects on it. Twelve word cards for Activity 3: *kettle, pillow, ladder, toothbrush, wallet, iron, fridge, mirror, towel, suitcase, bin, candle*.

Activity 1: What's in the bag? (25 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Put your hand in the bag, hold one object without showing it, and describe it: "It's small. It's hard. It's made of metal." Learners guess. Show it.
2. Board three headings as they arise: *size, shape, material*. Fill them: *big, small, tiny, huge, long, short; round, square, flat, thin; metal, plastic, wood, glass, paper, cloth*.
3. Drill *It's made of…* with objects around the room. Learners point and say.
4. Invite learners to the front one at a time to feel an object in the bag and describe it for the class to guess. Help with words as needed and add them to the board.
5. Learners sort the words in section A of the handout and check in pairs.

Activity 2: What is it for? (20 minutes)

1. Hold up the scissors. Ask: "What is it for?" Board two ways to answer: *It's for cutting paper. You use it to cut paper.*
2. Drill both patterns with the eight objects from the bag.
3. Learners match the objects and uses in section B of the handout, then say each one as a full sentence to a partner.
4. Pairs read the four mystery descriptions in section C and write the object. Check as a class.

Activity 3: I don't know the word (30 minutes, teacher-led then groups)

1. Tell learners that in the exam they may see something in a picture and not know its name. Stopping is the only wrong answer. Describing it is a good answer.
2. Board four rescue phrases and drill them: *I don't know the word in English, but… It's a thing for… It's like a… You find it in a…*
3. Model with a word they will not know, such as a colander: "I don't know the word, but it's a thing for washing rice or vegetables. It's round and made of metal. It has small holes. You find it in a kitchen."
4. Groups of four with the twelve word cards face down. A learner takes a card and describes the object without saying the word. The group guesses. Learners who do not know the word on their card may show you and ask quietly.
5. After ten minutes, change the rule: the describer must use at least one rescue phrase.
6. Feedback: praise the best descriptions you heard and repeat them for the class.

Activity 4: Something important to me (20 minutes)

1. Show an object of your own, such as your watch or a pen, and talk about it for a minute: what it looks like, where you got it, why it matters.
2. Learners choose something they have with them or at home. They make four notes: *what it is; what it looks like; where it is from; why I like it*.
3. Pairs tell each other. The listener asks two questions.
4. Two volunteers speak to the class.

Activity 5: A picture full of things (25 minutes)

1. Show the photo of the table with many objects. Learners look for 30 seconds, then you hide it. In pairs they list everything they remember.
2. Show it again. Model a one-minute description: the whole picture, then three objects with size, material and use, then an opinion about whose table it might be.
3. Pairs take turns to describe the same photo for a minute each, choosing different objects.
4. The listener ticks section D of the handout.
5. Close: each learner describes one object in the room for the class to guess, in two sentences.

Answer key, Lesson 9

- **Section A:** Size: tiny, huge, small. Shape: round, square, long, flat. Material: metal, plastic, wooden, glass, paper.
- **Section B:** 1 C, 2 E, 3 D, 4 F, 5 A, 6 B.
- **Section C:** 1 a key. 2 a toothbrush. 3 a phone. 4 a clock or a watch.